



CITY OF AMSTERDAM

SMART GROWTH COMPREHENSIVE PLAN 2026

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY



A Plan for the Next Chapter

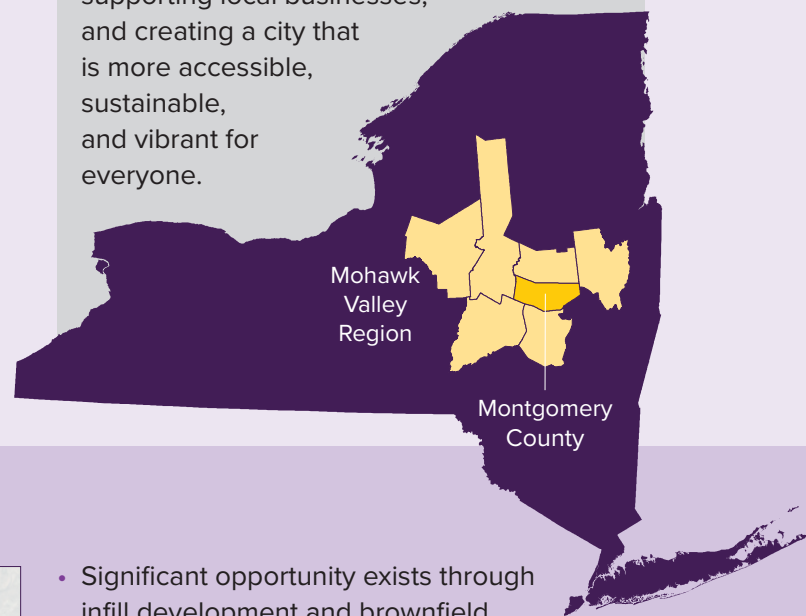
The City of Amsterdam’s Smart Growth Comprehensive Plan establishes a clear vision and framework to guide the city’s future over the next decade.

As one of the most important policy tools available to the City, the Comprehensive Plan documents existing conditions, defines a shared vision, and outlines goals and strategies to guide decision-making, investment, and development. The Plan also serves as the official guide for planning efforts and informs land use, budgeting, economic development, housing, environmental protection, transportation, and community service issues and policies.

This Plan builds on Amsterdam’s 2003 Comprehensive Plan and highlights more than two decades of change in economic conditions, population changes and trends, and community values. It will be a living document. The Plan will have a planning horizon of ten years. This is the length of time for which the 2024 Plan is considered relevant and representative of the community. The Plan will be reviewed regularly and updated when needed to ensure it continues to represent the needs and goals of the community.

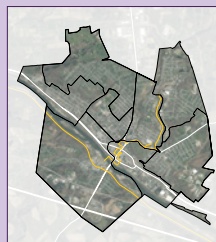
What This Plan Means for You

For residents, businesses, and community partners, this Plan is about improving everyday life in Amsterdam. It means better access to housing that meets a range of needs, more opportunities to live and work within the community, improved public spaces, and stronger, more connected neighborhoods. It also means that future development will be more intentional, focused on revitalizing existing areas, supporting local businesses, and creating a city that is more accessible, sustainable, and vibrant for everyone.



Key Plan Takeaways

- Amsterdam is experiencing renewed investment, particularly in downtown and waterfront areas.
- Smart Growth principles guide future development and reinvestment.
- Housing challenges, vacancy, affordability, and aging stock, are central issues.



- Significant opportunity exists through infill development and brownfield redevelopment.
- Economic growth depends on better connections between jobs and workforce.
- The Plan focuses on targeted investment in neighborhoods, corridors, and key districts.

From its early development along the Mohawk River and Erie Canal to its rise as a manufacturing center, Amsterdam's history continues to shape the city today. Its history with industry, immigration, and neighborhood development has created the city's physical and cultural identity, while past challenges including loss of its economic anchors and subsequent population decline, highlight the need for thoughtful planning.

At an important moment in its history, Amsterdam is confronting longstanding challenges and building new momentum for the

future. With recent investments in downtown, ongoing revitalization efforts in key target areas and along the waterfront, and a renewed focus on economic and community development, the city is shaping a more vibrant and connected future.

This Plan builds on that momentum by emphasizing revitalization, preservation, and reconnection, leveraging Amsterdam's historic assets and community character to support long-term resilience and growth.

A Smart Growth Approach to the Future

A new and defining feature of this Plan is its foundation built on New York State Department of State Smart Growth principles. These principles promote development patterns that are environmentally sustainable, economically efficient, socially equitable, and resilient. They emphasize compact, walkable neighborhoods; a mix of land uses; a diversity of housing options; and the preservation of natural resources.

What this looks like in Amsterdam is focusing investment in areas where infrastructure and community assets already exist, such as downtown, in established neighborhoods, and in key corridors while revitalizing underutilized land and reconnecting parts of the city that have become disconnected over time. This includes promoting mixed-use development along corridors like Main Street, encouraging infill development on vacant and brownfield sites in areas such as the East End and West End, and strengthening connections to the Mohawk River waterfront. The Plan also emphasizes the importance of public spaces, including parks, trails, and gathering areas like Riverlink Park, as well as expanded multi-modal transportation options that improve access across the city.

Smart Growth Principles

This Comprehensive Plan uses Smart Growth principles to promote livable, sustainable, and equitable communities. They include:

- **Mixed-Use Neighborhoods**
- **Housing Diversity**
- **Compact Design**
- **Quality Public Spaces**
- **Strategic Infill Development**
- **Multi-Modal Transportation**
- **Community Collaboration**
- **Placemaking**
- **Sustainability & Resiliency**
- **Resource Preservation**

Together, these strategies support a more connected, efficient, and livable community.

Building on Past Efforts

This Comprehensive Plan builds on a range of prior plans and studies that have shaped Amsterdam's revitalization efforts over the past 20 years, covering a span of 2003 to 2026. These include the City's earlier Comprehensive Plan, Brownfield Opportunity Area (BOA) studies in the East End, West End, and Northern Neighborhoods, the Downtown Revitalization Initiative (DRI), and the Local Waterfront Revitalization Program (LWRP).

Together, these efforts have identified opportunities to redevelop underutilized land, strengthen neighborhoods, enhance the waterfront, and generally promote needed economic growth. This Plan brings these initiatives together into a coordinated framework, catalogs past investments and planning efforts with a unified vision for the City's future.

Understanding Amsterdam Today

A central component of the Plan is an analysis of Amsterdam's people, neighborhoods, housing, economy, and land use patterns. This analysis highlights both the City's strengths and the challenges that must be addressed to support long-term revitalization and growth.

Amsterdam's neighborhoods vary significantly across the City's five wards, reflecting different levels of stability, housing conditions, and economic opportunity. While some areas are characterized by stable, owner-occupied neighborhoods, others face higher vacancy rates, aging housing stock, lower incomes, and greater reinvestment needs. These differences reinforce the importance of targeted, neighborhood-specific strategies that build on existing strengths while addressing areas of disinvestment.

The City's population is projected to stabilize following decades of decline, while becoming increasingly diverse, including a growing Hispanic community that contributes to Amsterdam's cultural and economic identity. At the same time, the City faces ongoing housing challenges, including an aging housing stock, high vacancy rates, and affordability pressures for many renters and homeowners.

Economic trends reflect both opportunity and disconnect. Amsterdam continues to support jobs in sectors such as healthcare, manufacturing, and public administration, yet many residents commute outside the city for work and household incomes remain below regional averages. Vacancy and underutilized land—particularly within former industrial and brownfield areas—also present opportunities for reinvestment, infill development, and economic growth.

Together, these conditions point to a city with strong assets, distinct neighborhoods, and significant potential, but one that will require coordinated, long-term investment to support a more equitable, connected, and resilient future.



Chuctanunda Creek (MP Photography)

A Shared Vision for Amsterdam's Future

A Plan's vision statement articulates its aspirations for the future and establishes the overarching direction for the Plan's goals, policies, and implementation strategies over the next decade.

Amsterdam's vision for the future is bold and ambitious!

Amsterdam is experiencing a resurgence. We are working to revitalize our downtown, enhance our waterfront, strengthen our neighborhoods, and change our image for the better. We recognize that there is more work to do, but we will build on our long history of community planning and leverage our recent successes to carry today's momentum forward to redefine Amsterdam for tomorrow.

The Comprehensive Plan establishes a shared vision for a more connected, resilient, and vibrant Amsterdam, one that builds on the City's strengths while addressing longstanding challenges through coordinated investment and Smart Growth strategies. The vision emphasizes stronger neighborhoods, expanded economic opportunity, improved mobility, and enhanced connections to parks, waterfronts, and natural resources and recommends specific actions.

To guide implementation, the Plan organizes its goals, objectives, and actions around four interconnected focus areas that shape future decision-making and investment across the City.

Focus Areas

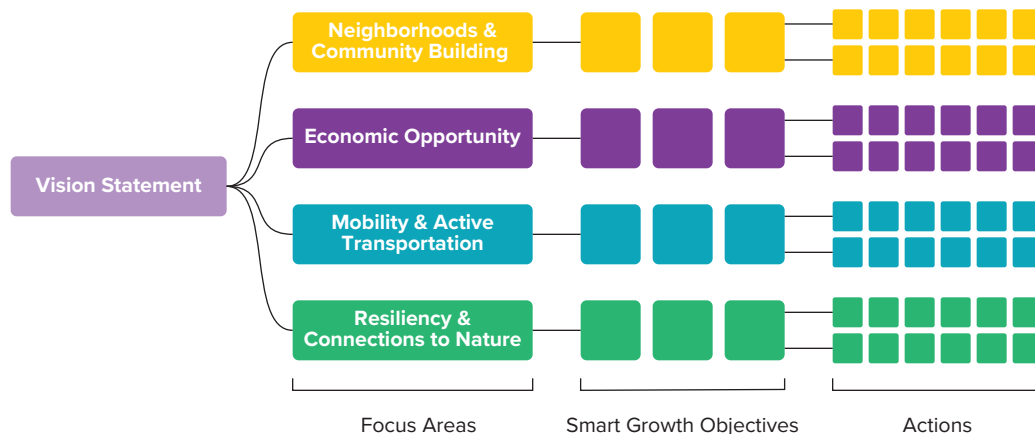
Nearhoods & Community Building.

Focuses on housing, neighborhoods, and community identity through strategies that support reinvestment, reduce vacancy, improve housing conditions, and strengthen neighborhood stability.

Economic Opportunity. Supports business growth, redevelopment, tourism, and workforce opportunity by building on assets such as downtown, industrial areas, and the waterfront.

Mobility & Active Transportation. Promotes walkability, bicycle infrastructure, multi-modal transportation, and improved connections between neighborhoods, downtown, parks, and community destinations.

Resiliency & Connections to Nature. Emphasizes environmental sustainability, waterfront access, parks, trails, and climate resilience while strengthening connections to the Mohawk River and Chuctanunda Creek.



From Vision to Action

Together, these focus areas provide the framework for the Plan's Smart Growth objectives and implementation strategies—creating a coordinated approach to revitalization, reinvestment, and long-term community resilience.

A Strategy for Smart, Targeted Growth

To achieve this vision, the Plan outlines a coordinated community development strategy focused on key areas of the city. This strategy is rooted in Smart Growth principles and emphasizes targeted investment, reinvestment, and revitalization.

Neighborhoods are a central focus, with strategies aimed at stabilizing housing, improving property conditions, and enhancing neighborhood identity. Downtown is identified as a key driver of economic and cultural activity, with continued investment needed to support businesses, improve public spaces, and strengthen connections to surrounding areas.

Downtown is identified as a key driver of economic and cultural activity. Building on recent investments through the Downtown Revitalization Initiative, the Plan calls for continued efforts to attract businesses, enhance public spaces, and strengthen connections between downtown and surrounding neighborhoods, including the South Side and waterfront areas.

Mixed-use corridors, particularly along Main Street and other key connectors, are envisioned as active, connected spaces that support a blend of residential, commercial, and community uses, while industry centers,

including areas such as the Edson Street Industrial Park, are identified as important employment hubs with opportunities to support business growth and job creation.

At the same time, the Plan emphasizes the importance of lining up workforce development with these opportunities to ensure that residents can access available jobs. In addition, enhancing the natural environment, including the Mohawk River and surrounding green spaces, as both community assets and critical components of long-term resilience, is key to the city's vision.

Across all of these focus areas, the Plan emphasizes the importance of connectivity, physically, economically, and socially. Improving transportation options, strengthening links between neighborhoods, and ensuring access to services and opportunities are all key components of the City's strategy.

Community Development Strategy

The Community Development Strategy presented in the Plan takes a location-based approach to growth, focusing on key areas across Amsterdam that present the greatest opportunities for community investment and revitalization. By identifying specific challenges and strategies for neighborhoods, downtown, corridors, industry centers, and the natural environment, the Plan provides a clear framework for coordinated and targeted action.

Focus Areas and What We're Addressing



FOCUS AREA Neighborhoods

Aging housing stock, high vacancy in some areas, and varying levels of stability across neighborhoods and wards.

KEY STRATEGIES

- Improve housing conditions and property maintenance
- Reduce vacancy and support reuse of underutilized properties
- Encourage reinvestment in existing neighborhoods
- Strengthen neighborhood identity and stability

WHAT IT MEANS

Stronger, more stable neighborhoods with improved housing quality and long-term investment.



FOCUS AREA Industry Centers

Need for job growth, business attraction, and stronger alignment between workforce and employment opportunities.

KEY STRATEGIES

- Support existing industrial areas such as Edson Street Industrial Park
- Attract new businesses and investment
- Strengthen workforce development connections
- Improve access and infrastructure to support employment centers

WHAT IT MEANS

Expanded economic opportunity and more accessible jobs for residents.



FOCUS AREA Downtown

Underutilized spaces, need for increased activity, and opportunities to build on recent public investment

KEY STRATEGIES

- Build on Downtown Revitalization Initiative (DRI) projects
- Enhance public spaces and streetscapes
- Attract and support local businesses
- Strengthen connections to surrounding neighborhoods and the waterfront

WHAT IT MEANS

A vibrant, active city center that serves as a hub for economic and community life.



FOCUS AREA Natural Environment

Flood risk, underutilized waterfront areas, and the need to protect natural resources while improving access.

KEY STRATEGIES

- Protect and enhance the Mohawk River and Chuctanunda Creek
- Expand access to parks, trails, and open space
- Support climate resilience and sustainability initiatives
- Integrate natural features into community development

WHAT IT MEANS

A more resilient, accessible, and environmentally sustainable city.



FOCUS AREA Mixed-Use Corridors

Disconnected commercial areas, limited walkability, and underutilized corridor spaces.

KEY STRATEGIES

- Promote mixed-use development along key corridors such as Main Street
- Improve walkability and streetscape design
- Enhance connectivity between neighborhoods and activity centers
- Support small-scale commercial and community uses

WHAT IT MEANS

More walkable, connected corridors that support local businesses and everyday activity.



Edward Street Senior Housing Project Rendering

Moving Forward

The Amsterdam Smart Growth Comprehensive Plan provides a roadmap for the City's future—one that is grounded in data, informed by community values, and focused on practical, achievable outcomes. By coordinating policies, investments, and partnerships, the Plan creates a framework for coordinated action across all aspects of community development.

Ultimately, this Plan is about creating a city that works better for its residents which means revitalized neighborhoods, expanded economic opportunity, improved housing options, and stronger connections between people and places. It reflects a commitment to building a community that is inclusive, resilient, and positioned for long-term success.

As Amsterdam continues to evolve, this Plan will serve as a guide, helping the city move forward with purpose, clarity, and a shared vision for the future.

